

SOME NOTES ON MACCRIMMON CANNTAIREACHD.

WHAT CANNTAIREACHD IS.

In the days when Staff Notation was unknown in the Highlands the old masters taught their pupils by a system of chanting, called Canntaireachd. There were various systems, the MacCrimmon, MacArthur, Campbell, etc., but the inference is the MacCrimmon system was the parent system, upon which the others were based.

The basis of Canntaireachd is the vowel sounds, but, as there are not enough of these to account for all the notes on the chanter, certain consonants are used in conjunction with certain vowels to indicate a different note on the chanter to that appertaining to the vowel sound without its qualifying consonant. Other consonants are used to indicate grace notes, or their absence, and in this way articulate syllables are built up, which represent certain movements or beats on the chanter.

The method might be described as onomatopœic, and consequently the vocables are intended to convey to the hearers the sound that the combination of notes and grace notes makes when played on the chanter. This point should not be overlooked, for each syllable of a vocable reproduces a note on the chanter which should be distinctly heard. There are many beats played to-day as one "syllable" which are shown in Canntaireachd as of two "syllables." The inference is, therefore, that much can be learnt, and many errors in modern playing corrected, from careful study of this point alone.

GESTO'S PUBLICATION.

In 1828 Captain Neil MacLeod of Gesto published twenty tunes in Canntaireachd, "*as taken from John MacCrummen, piper to the old Laird of MacLeod and his grandson, the late General MacLeod of MacLeod.*" This publication has been a puzzle to many, and is undoubtedly full of inconsistencies and errors. It must be remembered, however, that the system is really verbal, and to reduce the sounds of the vocables to black and white the very greatest care in the recording of the vowel sounds would be necessary. Realising this, therefore, we must not be too critical in discussing Gesto's publication, for it would be a difficult matter, to-day, to write down *correctly* and *consistently* tunes dictated in Canntaireachd.

In studying Gesto one must keep in view not so much the letters actually used, but the *sound* those letters are intended to convey! Great allowance must also be made for undoubted printers' or clerical errors.

A point which should be kept in view, in dealing with any written or printed collection of tunes in Canntaireachd, is that the tunes were probably reduced to black and white in comparatively recent years, very long after they were composed, and, most probably, by players who recorded their own versions, many of them mutilated or incomplete. Canntaireachd versions, therefore, even the tunes taken from Iain Dubh MacCrimmon himself, are as open to criticism in this respect as the collections in staff notation. In fact, there is no doubt that many of Gesto's twenty tunes are much mutilated.

Since Gesto's publication little of any importance seems to have appeared in print, except, perhaps, an article on Nether-Lorn Canntaireachd in *The Pipes of War* and some details in a recent issue of the Piobaireachd Society. It is to be regretted that nothing of real value dealing with the MacCrimmon system has come to light since Gesto published the collection of twenty tunes.

AN AUSTRALIAN AUTHORITY.

However, there is in Australia an old piper who was taught by the MacCrimmon Canntaireachd system, and he is, undoubtedly, one of the few remaining who can claim to have knowledge of the old methods. This is Mr. Simon Fraser, now of Melbourne. He was taught by Peter Bruce, the piper who competed at Edinburgh in 1838, *vide* the Introduction in Angus MacKay's Collection of Tunes. Mr. Simon Fraser's father was well known to Captain Neil MacLeod of Gesto and to Iain Dubh MacCrimmon, and, moreover, Mr. Simon Fraser's mother was a granddaughter of Charles MacArthur, and she also knew much of the system. Mr. Fraser knows two systems of Canntaireachd, what he calls the old system, given in Gesto, and a newer system, said by him to have been perfected by Patrick Mor MacCrimmon. This newer system adheres more closely than the old to the indicative vowel sounds and is more easily translated in consequence.

SOME NOTES ON MACCRIMMON CANNTAIREACHD—*continued.*

KEY TO THE SYSTEMS.

Coming now to the system itself, the following is a table of the sounds in both systems, Gesto's and Mr. Simon Fraser's, with the letters apparently intended to be used by Gesto and the letters used by Mr. Fraser:—

Note on Chanter	GESTO'S		MR. FRASER'S	
	Sound.	Letters.	Sound.	Letters.
A'	.. dee	.. di	.. dee or vee	.. dee or veet†
G'	.. oo	.. u	.. oo	.. u
F	.. ee	.. i	.. ee	.. i
E*	.. i as in high	.. ie	.. a as in may	.. e
D	.. a as in far	.. a	.. a as in far	.. a
C	.. o } perhaps one	.. o	.. i as in high	.. ie
B	.. o } of them yo	.. o	.. o as in note	.. o
A	.. een	.. in	.. een	.. in
G	.. un	.. un §	.. un	.. un

* In both systems *u* is sometimes used for note E, when descending.

§ It is suggested that many of the *hien* and *hiem* beats in Gesto are probably meant for *humand* and *hum*. MS. not very clearly written, or printers' errors, could easily account for a point such as this.

† Sometimes *di* or *vi*.

The letter "i" opening most of the tunes in Gesto is clearly the note "E" sounded before any player breaks into his tune. Although "ie" is used for note E in the text of a tune it seems clear its sound is intended to be the same as the "i" referred to. Mr. Fraser uses the letter "e" for the same purpose as the "i" in Gesto.

Use of Consonants.

The consonants used in both systems are as given in the following table:—

Letter.	INDICATION.	Example.
H.	A cutting grace note, usually high G (sometimes high A) ..	hin
Ch.	A cutting grace note, usually E, in the Siubhal	ho-chin
D.	A cutting grace note, usually D, in the Siubhal and Taorluth Fosgailte beats, but it should be noted the letter is still used when the note is too high for the D cut	hindo hinda
	Also low G grace note before low A	din
	Also, in conjunction with <i>r</i> , a grip or throw	dro
	Also, in conjunction with <i>i</i> , the high A	dili
T.	Same as D, as a cutting grace note and, in conjunction with <i>r</i> , a grip or throw	hinto tra
R.	A beat to a lower note and, in conjunction with <i>d</i> or <i>t</i> , a grip or throw	hororo dro
B.	No grace note to the note to which it is prefixed	himbo
V.	Same as B	hova
N.	In conjunction with <i>i</i> , low A, and in conjunction with <i>u</i> low G	in un
M.	Same as N, but is used when next syllable commences with B, following the usual change in Gaelic	himbo

Although the above is a general outline of the system, there are occasions in regular Variation beats (and in some Ground beats also) where the letters cannot be translated literally. This is more the case in Gesto than with Mr. Fraser's system, as already indicated.

ILLUSTRATIONS IN STAFF NOTATION.

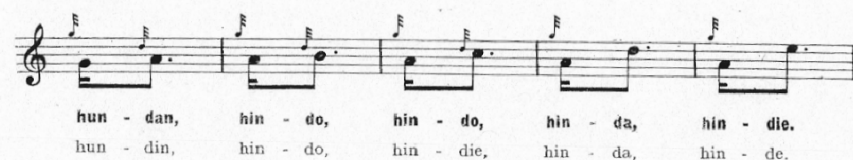
Illustrations in staff notation will now be given, and it should be understood that the Canntaireachd vocables in heavier type are from Gesto and those in lighter type from Mr. Fraser.

SOME NOTES ON MACCRIMMON CANNTAIREACHD—*continued.*

Before proceeding further, however, it should be explained a big note is used to represent each "syllable" heard in Canntaireachd, except for the cadencies, where, perhaps, modern practice is neater and less apt to confuse the time. This system, using a big note for each "syllable," is, it is considered, a very sound method of writing tunes in staff notation, and, were it followed regularly to-day, there might perhaps be less cause for unfavourable comment.

SIUBHAL BEATS.

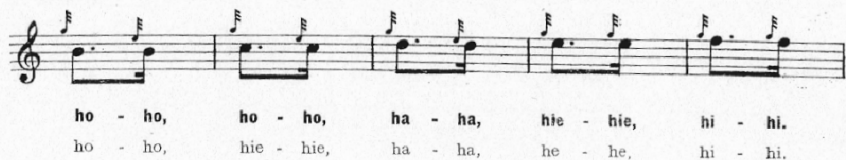
Ascending.



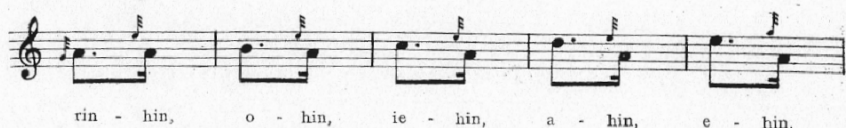
Descending.



Doubling.



Back-cutting.



There is, in Tune II. in Gesto (1st Variation), what appears to be a variety of the Siubhal beat, where the note A is doubled.



Students are no doubt aware that the above beat is usually played to the low G in this tune ("Marion's Wailing" or "The Royal Oak"), but, from the Piobaireachd Society's latest issue, it would seem that the Campbell collection of tunes in Canntaireachd, Donald MacDonald and J. MacKay have A instead of G, thus confirming Gesto and Mr. Fraser. Gesto uses the Taorluth form for this beat on A as does Mr. Fraser.

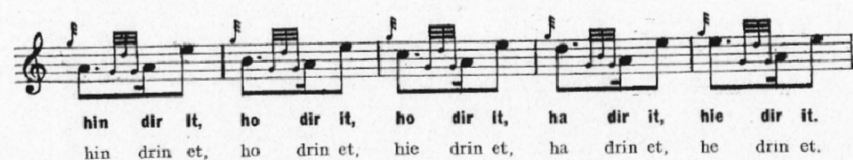
LEUMLUTH BEATS.

A close student of Gesto's publication would probably form the opinion there was no Leumluth beat in it, as he would, very naturally, come to the conclusion the "Hin-dir-it" beat was a Taorluth one. Mr. Simon Fraser, however, states very definitely that the "Hin-dir-it" beat is a Leumluth beat and that generally throughout the book the Taorluth Variations are omitted, except certain Taorluth Breabach and Mach Variations. It is with some diffidence, therefore, criticism is offered on Mr. Fraser's verdict. Close study of Gesto demonstrates that the vocable "Hin-dir-in" is used for the A beat in Mach Variations, and this supports Mr. Fraser's dictum that the Taorluth beat ends in "dir-in" and the Leumluth beat in "dir-it"! On the other hand, it will be found the Breabach vocables are usually "Ho-dir-it-o," "Ha-dir-it-a," "Hin-dir-in-an," which is suggestive the "dirt" vocable as Leumluth is open to criticism, because the Breabach beat is simply the closed Taorluth beat followed by another note. Deducting the added syllable, we are left with "Ho-dir-it," "Ha-dir-it," etc., representing the Taorluth! Moreover, in Tune XIII., a Mach Variation will be found as the Doubling of what Mr. Fraser calls a Leumluth Variation, which is very unusual. If Mr. Fraser is correct, and it is difficult to dispute the teaching he received from Peter Bruce, it would seem the Leumluth Variation was in much more common use at the time of Gesto than it is to-day, but it is

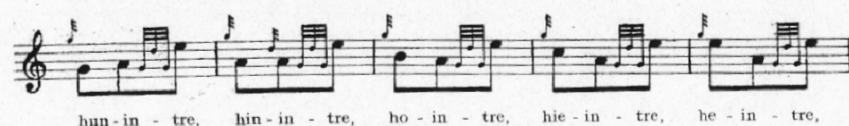
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difficult to account for Gesto's reason in giving Leumluth Variations and no Taorluth Variations! Students will no doubt form their own conclusions on the point, which, after all, is perhaps not of very great importance.

The Leumluth beats are given with Mr. Fraser's vocables, also Gesto's ending in "t," which letter, Mr. Fraser states, is not pronounced but only written! It is interesting to note that here, as in the case of the Taorluth and Crunluth beats, Mr. Fraser brings in the low A, confirming the old method of writing this beat.



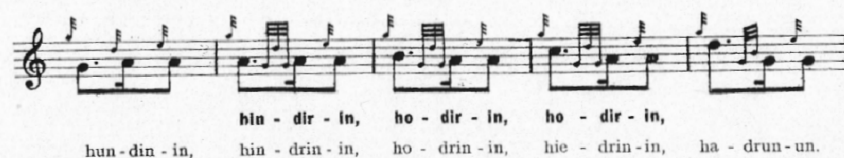
In addition, Mr. Fraser has what might perhaps be called a "back cutting" Leumluth beat, which is as follows:—



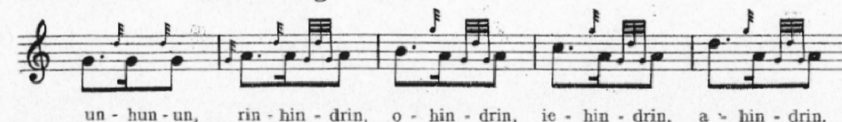
These "back cutting" beats, also those belonging to Taorluth, seem to confirm the old school in the contention there is a middle A in the beat, for here (as in the "back cutting" Taorluth) we have the middle A in *front* of the grip, instead of behind it!

TAORLUTH BEATS.

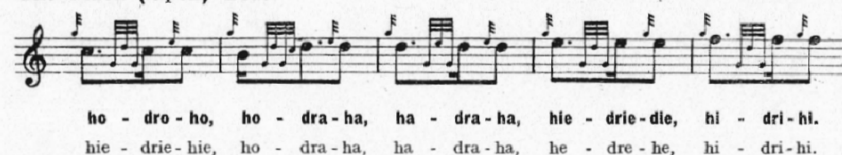
The ordinary closed Beat.



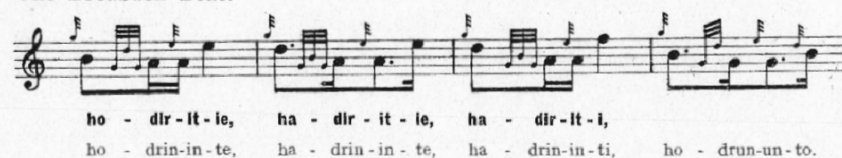
Mr. Fraser's "Back-cutting" Beat.



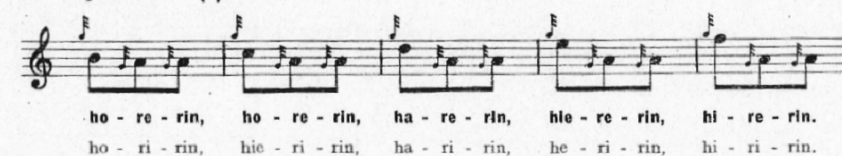
The Mach (Open) Beat.



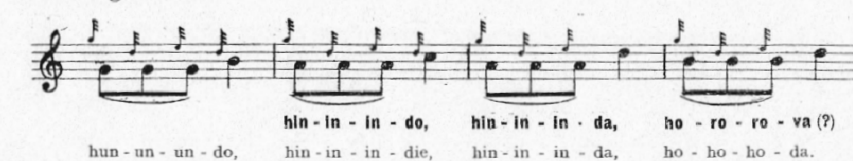
The Breabach Beat.



An unpublished (?) Beat.



The Fosgailte Beat.



The Gesto vocables given for the ordinary closed beats are those described as the correct MacCrimmon vocables (old system) by Mr. Simon Fraser, although not actually appearing in Gesto. The vocables on the lower line are those given by Mr. Fraser as appertaining to the newer MacCrimmon system. The question as to whether the "Hin-dir-it" beat in Gesto is Leumluth or Taorluth has already been discussed

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under the head of Leumluth Beats, and students of the system can form their own conclusions on the point.

Mr. Fraser's "back cutting" scale is interesting, and, perhaps, not much known to-day!

The unpublished (?) beat appears in Gesto's Tunes IV. and V., and has not, it is thought, appeared in staff notation before this. It would seem to be a form of Taorluth, hence the reason for being placed here.

It will be noted that Gesto has nothing to indicate the triplet on low G in the Fosgailte beat, whereas Mr. Fraser's method is quite clear in this respect.

CRUNLUTH BEATS.

There has been some controversy, at one time and another, in the *Oban Times* as to these beats in Gesto, but, on the whole, nothing has appeared to elucidate them. In fact, there are beats in No. III. tune which have been described as "Breabach" when called "Mach" in Gesto. The real question, as regards this tune, No. III., is—What does "Mach" mean, or what did it mean, in those days, so far as pipe music is concerned? "Mach" means "outside," and certainly this particular beat (which is *not* an *open* one) has extensions on the outside. However, of this later.

A careful analysis of *all* the Crunluth beats in Gesto (allowing for clerical and printers' errors, etc.) shows that there are at least ten forms of Crunluth in the book. Mr. Fraser has the same beats in the newer MacCrimmon Canntaireachd, and his vocables are given also.

The ten forms in Gesto are as follows:—

Closed Beats.

- (1) Three Syllables
(In ten out of the twenty tunes).



- (2) Four Syllables
(Tunes III., IV., VI., X. and XX)



- (3) Four Syllables
(Tunes I. and XIII.).



- (4) Five Syllables
(Tune VII.).



- (5) Six Syllables
(Tune IV.).



- (6) Seven Syllables
(Tune III.).



Fosgailte Beats.

- (7) Four Syllables
(Tunes VII., X., XII. and XX.)



Mach (Open) Beats.

- (8) Four Syllables
(Tune IV.).



SOME NOTES ON MACCRIMMON CANNTAIREACHD—*continued.*(9) Six Syllables
(Tune IV.).

Breabach Beats.

(10) Five Syllables
(Tunes XI. and XVI.).

Comment on the foregoing Beats.

METHOD OF WRITING THE BEATS.—Special attention is drawn to the way all the Crunluth beats herein are written as regards time. Mr. Fraser makes a strong point of timing the beats, both those given above and hereafter, as written. It will be noted the three syllable beat (ending in *tri* or *tre*), whether Fosgailte, Mach, or the ordinary closed beat, has each of the three melody notes of equal time value, whereas in the case of the four syllable beats (ending in *ti-ri* or *te-re*) the last two notes are halved in time value. This method of writing is not in accord with modern practice, but is perhaps suggestive of some change in the method of playing Crunluth beats since the time Mr. Fraser was taught by Peter Bruce. This change is very possibly the result of too expert fingering, for to-day the tendency is to rush the playing of a beat until its separate "syllables" are merged into a series of grace notes and little is left except the initial note. Mr. Fraser was taught to sound the beats as he writes them, each separate syllable receiving its due emphasis. This point is worthy of serious consideration, for it has great bearing on recent controversies as to the redundancy or otherwise of a middle note in Taorluth, Crunluth, etc.

BEAT No. 1 is the one in most common use to-day and the beat most frequently used in Gesto. In recent publications it has been written as shown on the right, as a *two* syllable beat without the middle A.



BEAT No. 2 occurs in three tunes in "closed" Variations and in the two others as a closed beat in Mach (Open) and Fosgailte Variations. The

difference between this and the preceding beat is the first E. In this beat it is a "syllable" and must be heard, whereas in the other it is a grace note so quickly played that it does not form a "syllable."

BEAT No. 3.—This beat in Tune I. is, in reality, the doubling of the "Hin-da-tri" Variation. In Tune XIII. the vocable is written "Hin-dra-trie-ri," but it is considered to be the same beat as "Hin-da-tri-ri." In the latter tune the variation is described as "Double," the previous variations consisting entirely of "Hin-da-tri" class beats. Seeing, therefore, the only difference between the two is the length of the beat, students should be convinced there would not be two such variations unless there was a difference in the form of the Crunluth! This is the first of the series of "extended" beats.

BEAT No. 4 is a *five* syllable beat from Tune No. VII. It will be noticed it is used for the last four beats of a *four* syllable Fosgailte Variation ("Hin-do-re-ri"). This by itself, apart from the proof existing in the Ground of the Tune, is almost conclusive evidence the last two bars (these four beats) and corresponding bars throughout do not belong to the tune. Nevertheless this Crunluth beat is probably perfectly correct as a MacCrimmon beat.

BEAT No. 5.—This six syllable beat is a closed beat from a Mach (Open) Variation in Tune IV. The 3rd Variation of this tune consists of a four syllable closed beat "Hin-da-ti-ri," and its Doubling of an open four syllable beat (although not called "Mach") "Ho-dro-ti-ri." This beat, No. 5, is from the "Crouluigh Mach" or "Last Part," and is a closed one (for the open beat in the same Variation see No. 9).

BEAT No. 6 is from Tune No. III. The 3rd Variation is a three syllable beat, "Hin-da-tri"; the 4th a four syllable beat, "Hin-da-tri-ri," and this beat No. 6 is a seven syllable beat from the "Last Part," described as "Crouluigh Mach or Finishing Measure," although it is clearly a closed beat and not an open one. This leads one to doubt the meaning of "Mach" as applied in modern practice, and rather confirms the idea the term means an "extended" beat (on the "outside") rather than an "open" one.

SOME NOTES ON MACCRIMMON CANNTAIREACHD—*continued.*

BEAT NO. 7.—This Fosgailte beat in Gesto is invariably a four syllable beat. It will be noticed the other beats (closed beats, from E, etc.), in Fosgailte Variations are also four syllable beats. For instance, see Gesto's Tune X., where the Fosgailte beat is "Hin-to-rie-ri" and the closed beat "Hie-da-ti-ri" (as shown on the right).



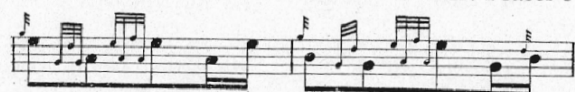
It would seem a mere matter of fancy, depending upon the whim of the player, whether or not the Fosgailte Crunluth is played "open" or "closed." In any case, it is entirely wrong to repeat the Variation in "open" form, after having played it in the "closed" form, with the idea it is a species of "Mach" Variation.

The tendency to-day is to rush the second note of the Fosgailte beat and not give it the clear emphasis it should receive.

BEAT NO. 8 appears in only one Tune (No. IV.) It is a four syllable open beat and is well known.

BEAT NO. 9 is a six syllable open beat and appears in the same tune as the preceding beat. The corresponding six syllable closed beat (from the same Variation) is No. 5, and reference might be made to the remarks regarding that beat. It will be noted both beats are identical in form, one closed and the other open.

BEAT NO. 10.—There are only two examples of this in Gesto, Tunes XI. and XVI. The style is the same in both, but there is nothing in these tunes to indicate the form used when low G is intended. Mr. Fraser's vocable is clear in this respect, as illustrated.



He - drin - tre - in - de Ho - drun - tre - un - do

Some doubtful Beats in Gesto.

As is to be expected, there are certain Crunluth beats in Gesto which are hard to follow.

The vocables for the Crunluth Fosgailte in Tune No. XII. appear to suggest the beat is "open," *vide* the change in the third syllable.

In Tune XVIII. there are two kinds of three syllable vocables not used in other tunes—The 3rd Variation—"Hin-die-dru," and its Doubling, "Hin-did-tri." The only apparent difference between these Variations seems to be the replacement of certain Singling beats by Crunluth beats in the Doubling. There is nothing to indicate that the beats differ from the usual three syllable beat, "Hin-da-tri," and one can only form the conclusion the meaning is the same. Perhaps the difference may be accounted for by the tune having been taken down at a different time from the others or by the fact that the "old masters" used various vocables for the same beat!

Tune No. XX. seems hopelessly mixed up. It is unlikely the Singling of the Third Variation would contain more syllables than the Doubling. The only difference between the two appears to be the replacement, in the Doubling, of certain beats ("hio-dro," "hie-ie-drie," etc.), in the Singling, and it seems evident the Singling beat is meant to be one of four syllables—"Hin-da-di-ri," a simple Fosgailte beat!

Other Crunluth Beats from Mr. Fraser.

In addition to the ten varieties of Crunluth beats found in Gesto, Mr. Fraser has other Crunluth beats which are deserving of attention, although the differences from those already dealt with may not be very great.

1. A three syllable Fosgailte beat (all Gesto's are four syllables). The vocables do not distinguish between the closed and the open form, although he gives both, thus—



Hin - do - tre, hin - do - tre, hin - die - tre, hin - die - tre.

2. A four syllable Fosgailte beat with a G cut before the first E, thus—



hun - din - te - re, hin - do - te - re, hin - do - te - re, hin - die - te - re.

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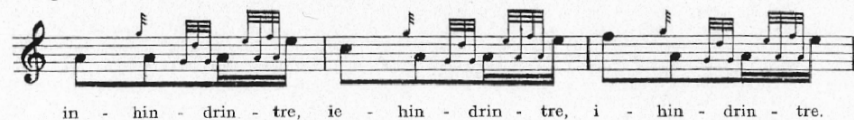
3. An "extended" Fosgailte beat, otherwise similar to No. 2, thus—



4. A three syllable Mach beat, Gesto's Mach beats being four syllables—



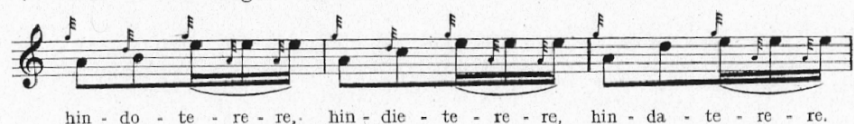
5. A "back-cutting" beat of four syllables—



6. An "extended" back-cutting beat of six syllables—



7. A beat somewhat similar to No. 3 but with plain beats from the E, instead of doublings. Thus—



In fact, it would seem that all the beats already described could be varied like the last example, *i.e.*, by playing a low A single beat from the E instead of the usual "doubling" of the E. This would seem to indicate an endless variety of Crunluth "fancies," and leads one to the conclusion the celebrated "old masters" played just as their fingers "worked"—a long

extended beat on a warm day with everything going well and, perhaps, a curtailed beat if less happy circumstances existed!

GROUND BEATS.

We now come to the Ground and to the various beats and points in connection therewith.

Mr. Fraser draws attention to the difference between Gesto's and MacKay's method of starting many tunes. Gesto may start a tune as shown on the left, whereas in MacKay it may be as shown on the right. He I him bo tra o says Gesto's method is more correct and in accordance with old custom, and that MacKay had a "way of his own."

Double Beats.

The double beats might next be referred to—



One might comment on the playing of certain of them. For instance, MacDonald and Ross give the double beat on D, as shown on the left, with the first grace note (apart from the cadence) a beat on C instead of low G. Many play the beat this way to-day, and who shall say they are wrong! It might also be noted that MacDonald frequently gives a G,F,E cadence to this beat, which has a fine effect in certain tunes! He does not give a "throw," however, but shows the grace notes for the last part of the beat—G,C, and not G,D,C. This is possibly a clerical error? (See illustration on the right).

SOME NOTES ON MACCRIMMON CANNTAIREACHD—*continued.*

The principal source of argument is the playing of the double beat on low A. It is to-day often written as shown on the left, and generally played this way. The late Iain MacLennan wrote the beat as shown on the right, and this method of playing it is more logical than the other, taking into consideration the sound of the other double beats. The Canntaireachd indicates that all these beats (apart from the cadencies) are *three* syllable beats. This being the case, it is difficult to find a logical reason for the method adopted to-day of playing the beat on A. Too expert fingering possibly accounts for what is undoubtedly an incorrect method. The rhythm of most tunes demands the three "syllables," and pipers would be well advised to get away from modern convention and play the beat to suit the tune. In fact, there are tunes where a longer rest on the first A than the last would be more appropriate.

It is interesting to note that Mr. Fraser often records the low A beat in staff notation (as shown on the right) with the second low G a big note and not a grace note, thus supplanting the birl by the present-day method used with the other beats.

Throws, Grips, Etc.

dro, o dro, dro, o dro, dra, a dra, o dra.
dro, o dro, drie, ie drie, dra, a dra, o dra.

trie, bie trie, tri, bi tri, di - li, dili.
tre, be tre, tri, bi tri, dee - lee, deelee.

hie di ri vi u, hie di ri vu a, di ri ro.
he di ri vi u, he di ri vu a, ra rie ro.

hi o di ri ro, dro di ri ro, trie di ri ro.
he ie ra rie ro, drie ra rie ro, tre ra rie ro.

hi a ra din, hi o ro din, hi o din, hi o din, hi o en in.
he a ro din, he ie ro din, he ie din, he o din, he o in un.

It is hardly necessary to point out the differences between the one and the two syllable beats, "Dro," "O-dro"; "Trie," "Bie-trie"; "Tri," "Bi-tri"; etc. The difference between "Tri" and "Tr-ri" in the Crunluth beats has already made it clear that beats such as "O-dro," "Bie-trie," etc., should *not* be written as shown on the right.

It is interesting to note that Mr. Fraser writes the "Dra" beat with the grip, as it is usually written in Glen. This method has been described as the "new" way of playing the beat. It is more likely that the method of playing it *without* the grip is the "new" method!

It is necessary to comment on the way the "Ha-ro-din," "Ho-ro-din" beats are usually written in staff notation. The main accent is often wrongly placed on the low A (as shown on the left). Careful study, and comparison with corresponding variation beats, makes it amply clear the accent should almost invariably be placed on the *first* note of the beat, and not the *last*, as shown above. The beat is, of course, a *three* syllable beat, and the latest fashion of writing it as a *two* syllable one (as shown on the right) cannot be too severely condemned. Each "syllable" should be heard.

On the other hand the "di-ri-ro" beat is usually correctly accented on the "ro," as illustrated on the left. It should not, of course, be written as a single syllable beat, as shown on the right.

SOME NOTES ON MACCRIMMON CANNTAIREACHD—*continued.*

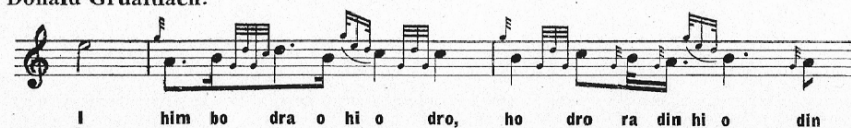
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The “di-li” beat (throw on high A) has been written in above table as a *two* syllable beat and also as a single syllable beat, although it might be conceded the way of writing it as shown on the right in above table is more satisfactory, and certainly more usual! Nevertheless, it is said the beat is often rushed, and the first high A should be more clearly heard than is usual in present-day practice.

TRANSLATION OF TUNES.

In light of the foregoing, the following translations of a few bars from “Donald Gruamach” and “Isabel MacKay” may not be uninteresting.

Donald Gruamach.



Isabel MacKay.



THE PLAYING OF THE LEUMLEUTH, TAORLUTH AND CRUNLUTH BEATS.

There has been much controversy, at one time and another, regarding the correct method of playing these beats. Upholders of the modern school maintain there is no middle A in the closed beats, or corresponding melody note in the Mach beats, whereas the old school generally argues the contrary.

Recently a fresh controversy has arisen in the columns of the *Oban Times*, resulting in a demonstration in Edinburgh on 25th March, 1926. Unfortunately, this discussion was not free from bias, even recrimination, and disclosed but little logical argument. The demonstration in Edinburgh apparently led to nothing, and was, so far as can be judged by newspaper reports, a most ill-timed, badly conceived and fruitless affair. It is much to be regretted that the discussion in the *Oban Times* was not developed in a logical way, thus forming the basis upon which an impartial committee of investigation could work and come to some definite conclusion.

It might be as well to quote arguments which can be used on both sides—

Arguments against the middle note.

(1) Traditional playing. Most modern players of note stating this is the way the beat was always played.

(2) The beat as written by MacDonald and MacKay was so written solely for the benefit of those wishing to produce the correct sound on other instruments than the chanter.

(3) Angus MacKay shows no middle A in his closed Taorluth beat from D.

(4) It cannot be played in time.

Arguments in favour of the middle note.

(5) Traditional playing. (This is, of course, as much an argument in favour of, as against, the middle note.)

(6) Donald MacDonald and Angus MacKay's method of writing the beats.

(7) The Taorluth Fosgailte beat contains three A's.

(8) The beats from low G are followed by A.

(9) The beats referred to in the footnote on page 148 of Angus MacKay's Collection.

(10) Closed Crunluth beats (from E, F, etc.), in Fosgailte Crunluth Variations.

(11) Canntaireachd and the Mach beats.

We will deal now with these various points, and endeavour to develop them as logically as possible.

TRADITIONAL PLAYING (Points 1 and 5). This is perhaps the most difficult argument to deal with, for we are faced with diametrically opposed statements from either side, and yet both sides trace their teaching, sometimes through a generation or two, to the same sources.

In the recent discussion Mr. J. F. Farquharson, late piper to H.R.H. the Duke of Edinburgh, stated (see *Oban Times* of March 6th and April 3rd, 1926) that in 1859 he was taught by Duncan Campbell, in 1861 by Donald Cameron, and in 1863 and part of 1864 by John Ban Mackenzie, to play the A in the closed beats. He also states that Colin Cameron, with whom he spent a long time in London, similarly played the A.

On the other hand, it is stated by others that Sandy Cameron, a brother of Donald Cameron, did not play the A. It is also said that other pupils of those who taught Mr. Farquharson do not play the A.

A well-known piper states he learnt to play without the A, from someone who learnt from Angus MacKay's fingers and practising chanter.

Malcolm Macpherson ("Calum Piobair") is said by some to have been taught (I am open to correction on this point) by Munro of Oban, who was taught by Peter Bruce of Glenelg, not to play the A.

Mr. Simon Fraser, of Australia, *who is still alive*, learnt directly from this same Peter Bruce, and was taught to play the A. Moreover, he was taught the Canntaireachd for the Taorluth beat as—"Hun-din-in, hin-drin-in, ho-drin-in, hie-drin-in, ha-drin-in," etc., and "Hun-din-tre, hin-drin-tre, ho-drin-tre," etc., for the Crunluth beat.